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LARGE The Ninth Bell

A Theona Adventure for LowFantasy and Creepy Elements

A Fate's Edge Adventure for Seasoned (Tier II) Characters

largeADVENTURE OVERVIEW

@ll **Setting:** Theona

Theme: The weight of broken oaths, cultural taboos, the land remembers

Focus: Lowfantasy horror, social tension, cultural consequence

Combat: Minimal (the true threat cannot be fought directly)

Length: 23 Sessions

largePREMISE TONE

In Theona, where the land remembers what you forget, a cultural taboo has been broken. The Ninth Law states: "The ninth word is never spoken, the ninth path is hidden, and the ninth name is erased from history." A bell has begun ringing where no bell should ring, marking the countdown to the Green Host's arrival.

This is not a story about monsters but about consequences. The horror is in the inevitability of the ninth chime, the weight of the land's memory, and the knowledge that no one can outrun what the land has witnessed. The bell rings for the dead who were not given their due, and the ninth chime will come at dawn.

largeTHE NINTH LAW

Theona's most sacred cultural principle is the Ninth Law. It governs everything from how many words should be spoken in a vow to how many names should be listed on a memorial stone. The Ninth Law is not just a traditionit is woven into the fabric of the land itself.

The Ninth Law Manifestations

tem **The Ninth Word:** Never spoken in a vow; if spoken, the vow is void and consequences follow tem **The Ninth Path:** Never taken; leads to places the land does not remember tem **The Ninth Name:** Erased from history; spoken only in the darkest moments tem **The Ninth Bell:** Never rung; its ringing means someone broke the Ninth Law

largeTHE HOOK

The adventure begins with one of these scenarios:

tem **The Ringing Bell:** Traveling through Theona's hills, you hear a bell ringing

The Green Host **Type:** Manifestation of Cultural Law

Description: Not a physical entity but a force of consequence

Appearance: Only perceived as a cold in the air, a distortion in vision, a sound like wind through dead trees

Nature: The land's enforcement mechanism for broken oaths

Weakness: Cannot be fought; only appeased through proper cultural ritual

Effect: The ninth chime will mark the moment when the land claims what was denied

LOCATIONS

The Silent Bell **Description:** A bell hanging from a single iron post on a windswept hill. No rope, no striker yet it rings.

Supernatural Features:

- tem Handprints in the snow lead to the bell but end where no human could stand
- tem Each chime echoes one more time than it should
- tem The ground is unnaturally cold around the bell

Cultural Significance: This bell only rings when the Ninth Law is broken; each chime represents a life that was not properly mourned

The Village of Stone **Description:** A village where no doors are locked but no voices are heard

Supernatural Features:

- tem Villagers communicate only through gestures and written notes
- tem Children are kept indoors; they point toward the hills and weep
- tem Every household has a ninth stone placed in a hidden corner

Cultural Significance: The village is observing the ritual silence that follows a broken Ninth Law

The Unmarked Grave **Description:** A fresh grave in a field, with no marker, no name

Supernatural Features:

- tem The earth has been turned but no footprints surround it
- tem A ninth flower grows in the center of the grave
- tem The soil is unnaturally cold to the touch

Cultural Significance: This is the grave of the person whose ninth name was spoken; it was dug by the land itself

THE TIMERS

The Bell's Countdown [9] The bell rings once every hour, counting down to dawn.

- tem **13 Chimes:** First signs of disturbance; villagers become anxious
- tem **46 Chimes:** The land reacts; cold spots, distorted sounds
- tem **78 Chimes:** The Green Host is

near; people feel watched, haunted tem **9 Chimes:** Dawn arrives; the Green Host claims its due

The Ninth Law Broken

tem **1:** Someone spoke the ninth name of a dead person tem **2:** The person who spoke it is known but unnamed tem **3:** The dead person's death was not properly mourned tem **4:** The dead person was denied a proper name

The Land's Memory The land remembers what you forget. As the Ninth Law is broken, the land's memory becomes more active.

tem **1:** Small disturbances (cold spots, distorted sounds) tem **2:** Visual distortions (seeing things that aren't there) tem **3:** The land actively hinders the living (paths disappear, landmarks shift) tem **4:** The Green Host is manifesting

largeCORE MECHANICS

The Ninth Name The ninth name is the true name of the dead, never to be spoken by the living.

tem Speaking the ninth name breaks the Ninth Law tem The name is only known by those who properly mourned the dead tem The land remembers the ninth name even if no living person does tem The bell rings for every ninth name that is spoken

The Green Host The Green Host is not a monster but the cultural consequence of breaking the Ninth Law.

tem **It cannot be fought:** It is the land's enforcement of cultural law tem **It cannot be hidden from:** The land knows where you are tem **It can only be appeased:** Through proper cultural ritual tem **It claims what was denied:** The ninth chime marks when the land takes what should have been given

Cultural Rituals Proper cultural ritual can prevent or mitigate the Green Host's arrival.

tem **Naming the Dead:** Speaking all nine names properly (including the ninth) tem **The Silent Vigil:** A period of silence and mourning tem **The Stone Offering:** Placing nine stones in a specific pattern tem **The Ninth Path:** Taking the path that is never taken to make things right

largeSESSION STRUCTURE

Session 1: The Bell Rings

tem **The Hook:** Players encounter the ringing bell or its consequences tem **Investigation:** Learn about the Ninth Law, discover someone spoke the ninth name tem

Cultural Tension: Experience the village's ritual silence and fear tem **First Clues:** Find the unmarked grave, learn about the person whose ninth name was spoken tem **First Chime:** Experience the bell's first unnatural echo

Session 2: The Land Remembers

tem **Rising Tension:** The land's memory becomes more active (cold spots, visual distortions) tem **Cultural Barrier:** Villagers communicate only through gestures and written notes tem **The Seventh Chime:** The Green Host is near; people feel watched tem **Discovery:** Learn the truth about who spoke the ninth name and why tem **The Eighth Chime:** The moment of decision what ritual will you perform?

Session 3: The Ninth Chime

tem **Dawn Approaches:** The final hours before the ninth chime tem **The Ritual:** Perform the proper cultural ritual to appease the land tem **The Green Host:** The land's consequence manifests tem **The Ninth Chime:** The moment when the land claims what was denied tem **Resolution:** The land returns to balance, or the consequences continue

THE RITUAL OF APPEASEMENT

The Proper Ritual To prevent the Green Host from claiming its due, the following ritual must be performed:

tem **Step 1:** Speak all nine names of the dead person (including the ninth) tem **Step 2:** Perform the Silent Vigil from dusk to dawn tem **Step 3:** Place nine stones in the pattern of the Ninth Path tem **Step 4:** Take the Ninth Path (a specific, hidden path known only to the elders)

Ritual Failure Consequences

tem **12 failed steps:** The Green Host will claim one person instead of many tem **34 failed steps:** The Green Host claims multiple people; the bell continues to ring tem **Complete failure:** The Green Host claims the entire village; the bell rings eternally

POSSIBLE RESOLUTIONS

Resolution Paths

tem **The Proper Ritual:** The land is appeased; the bell stops ringing. The village returns to normal, but the memory remains. PCs gain a cultural boon but also a responsibility to remember. tem **Partial Ritual:** The Green Host claims only the

person who broke the law. The bell stops, but the land is less forgiving. The village will remember the PC's role, for better or worse. tem **Failed Ritual:** The Green Host claims multiple people. The bell stops, but the land's memory is wounded. The Ninth Law becomes stricter in this region; future PCs will face harsher consequences for breaking it. tem **The Ninth Path:** The PCs take the Ninth Path themselves, becoming guardians of the Ninth Law. They gain deep understanding of Theona's cultural traditions but are forever marked by the land.

largeGM GUIDANCE

Creating Creepy Atmosphere

tem Describe the cold in the air that has no source tem Have the bell ring at unexpected moments, even when no one is near it tem Use the villagers' silence to create tension (no doors, but no voices) tem Describe visual distortions: "The path seems to stretch unnaturally long" tem Emphasize the inevitability of the ninth chime: "Dawn is coming"

LowFantasy Approach

tem The horror comes from cultural consequence, not from magic tem Avoid explaining how the bell rings; the "how" is less important than the "why" tem The Green Host is not a monster to fight but a cultural truth made manifest tem The land itself is the active force, not any supernatural entity tem The true terror is in knowing that no one can outrun what the land remembers

Pacing the Countdown

tem The first three chimes should feel like curiosity tem The next three should create growing unease tem The seventh and eighth should be moments of dread tem The ninth chime must feel inevitable

The Land as a Character

tem The land has memory and consequence tem It enforces cultural traditions through natural phenomena tem It is neither good nor evil, but it is absolute tem The land remembers what you forget

largeQUICK START FOR PCs

tem **Scholar:** Research the history of the Ninth Law, find the proper ritual tem **Cantor:** Use song to communicate with the land, or to break the ritual silence tem **Runekeeper:** Understand the weight of oaths and cultural agreements tem **Healer:** Tend to those affected by the land's memory, though the true cure is ritual tem **Wanderer:** Know the hidden paths, including possibly the Ninth Path

*"The ninth word is never spoken, the ninth path is hidden, and the ninth name is erased
from history."*

"The land remembers what you forget."

The Ninth Law of Theona